Path to Good

A Star Chart for Queering Contemplative Spirituality

Andrea Robin Studio

The Asking

for Rebecca Elson (1960–1999), astronomer and poet

Lost at sea, I did not pray.
I looked up.

The stars do not care
whether you find them useful.
That is what I love about them.

The iron in my blood
was made in a violence
I have no name for.
It crossed three billion years
to end up here, useful,
carrying oxygen to these particular thoughts
in this particular dark.

Consider that.

I have been lost in the wilderness
where the trees repeat themselves
the way trauma does,
each turn arriving
at the same clearing.

I looked up.

Not for guidance exactly —
the stars are not a map,
they are a fact,
and the fact is this:
you are already made of the thing
you thought you were seeking.

I have been lost in the desert
where my shadow at noon
was the only dark available,
and I lay down in it,
and I looked up,
and I thought:

the light arriving now
left its source
before I was a thought,
before the carbon was assembled
into whatever this is
that doubts and hungers —

and I was not comforted exactly
but I was
repositoned.

This is my religion:
that matter,
given enough pressure and time,
wakes up.

That somewhere in the forging
of iron in a dying star
the universe began
practicing
for us.

That what came out of the supernovae —
all that gorgeous debris —
arranged itself eventually
into something that could ask
why.

The asking is the thing.
Not the answer.
The asking.

Sometimes it is enough
to lie here in the wilderness,
the sea, the sand,
in whatever lostness
has found me this season,

and know that the dark overhead
is not empty
but full
of what we cannot yet see —

that I am inferred
the way dark matter is inferred,
by the way other things
move around me,

that even unconstrained by form
I was already here,
in the first warm scatter
of things becoming things.

We are a window.
Briefly.
The universe
looking at itself
and finding it
has questions.

That is enough.
That is more
than the stars
required of themselves.

The Stars

Thirty-five stars across eight constellations of equal dignity. No hierarchy. No sequence. Each star carries a scholarly anchor, a description, and bibliography roots. The lines between the stars in the chart are not sequences — they are relationships.

The Body's Wisdom

6 stars

Sensing the body from within

THE BODY'S WISDOM

Anchor	*Interoception — Anil Seth, Sarah Garfinkel*
Description	The brain's reading of its own internal state is the biological root of self-awareness and empathy. The self is a controlled hallucination built on bodily prediction. You cannot recognize the human in another without first learning to sense yourself.
References	Seth (2021) Being You · Garfinkel et al. (2015) Neuropsychologia · Siegel — The Mindful Brain

The nervous system as navigator

THE BODY'S WISDOM

Anchor	*Polyvagal theory — Stephen Porges*
Description	Three autonomic states: ventral vagal (safety, social engagement), sympathetic (fight/flight), dorsal vagal (freeze). Systems that hoard power dysregulate the body chronically. Repair through attuned presence returns us to ventral vagal. Intimacy is two nervous systems learning safety together.
References	Porges (2011) The Polyvagal Theory · Dana (2018) The Polyvagal Theory in Therapy · Shipherd & Aafjes-van Doorn (2021)

Window of tolerance

THE BODY'S WISDOM

Anchor	*Siegel — interpersonal neurobiology; Ogden — sensorimotor psychotherapy*
Description	The zone of arousal within which integration is possible. Chronic exposure to second-satan systems narrows this window. Contemplative and somatic practice widen it over time. The spiritual journey is partly the expansion of what the body can be present to.
References	Siegel (2007) The Mindful Brain · Ogden et al. (2006) Trauma and the Body · Treleaven (2018) Trauma-Sensitive Mindfulness

Trauma metabolized

THE BODY'S WISDOM

Anchor	*Levine — somatic experiencing; van der Kolk*
Description	Trauma is incomplete biological responses stored in the body. The path back runs through the body, not around it. Van der Kolk established that trauma reorganizes the brain's alarm system. The alchemy of pain is a literal, biological process — not metaphor.
References	van der Kolk (2014) The Body Keeps the Score · Levine (1997) Waking the Tiger · Treleaven (2018) Trauma-Sensitive Mindfulness

The difficult side of practice

THE BODY'S WISDOM

Anchor	*Britton — Cheetah House; Treleaven (2018)*
Description	Contemplative practice can be destabilising for those carrying second-satan wounds. Depersonalisation, increased anxiety, and psychotic episodes are documented in the research. No spiritual bypassing. Trauma-sensitive mindfulness is not optional. The difficult is part of the map.
References	Lindahl et al. (2017) PLOS ONE · Grof & Grof (1989) Spiritual Emergency · Treleaven (2018) Trauma-Sensitive Mindfulness

Contemplative neuroscience

THE BODY'S WISDOM

Anchor	*Davidson, Lutz, Lazar; Vessel et al. (2012)*
Description	Sustained practice produces measurable structural changes: thickened insula (interoception), enlarged prefrontal cortex (regulation), altered default mode network (reduced rumination). Profound aesthetic experience activates the same networks as meditation. Practice — and making — reorganize the brain.
References	Davidson & Begley (2012) · Lutz et al. (2004) PNAS · Vessel et al. (2012) Frontiers in

	Human Neuroscience · Kaimal et al. (2016) Art Therapy · Van Dam et al. (2018)

The Hearthstone

4 stars

Self-compassion as ground

THE HEARTHSTONE

Anchor	*Neff — three components; Coakley — kenosis as strength*
Description	Self-kindness, common humanity, mindfulness. The most empirically robust predictor of sustained wellbeing. Coakley's feminist kenosis: self-emptying not as submission but as groundedness from which genuine relating becomes possible. The North Star. You navigate from here, not toward here.
References	Neff (2011) Self-Compassion · Coakley (2002) Powers and Submissions · Fredrickson et al. (2008) Journal of Personality and Social Psychology

Rupture

THE HEARTHSTONE

Anchor	*Tronick — still face experiment; Bowlby; Ainsworth*
Description	Rupture is an ordinary feature of every intimate relationship from the earliest weeks of life. The body registers disconnection as threat. No cult of seamlessness. Rupture is the body telling its truth about its limits. Not a moral failure — not a policing of the self.
References	Tronick et al. (1978) American Journal of Diseases of Children · Bowlby (1988) A Secure Base · Ainsworth et al. (1978) Patterns of Attachment

Repair

THE HEARTHSTONE

Anchor	*Secure attachment — Mary Main; Porges — co-regulation*
Description	Secure attachment is not the absence of rupture but the reliable experience of repair. What predicts security in children is not perfect attunement but the capacity to return after rupture. Repair is the engine of real intimacy. The turning back toward.
References	Main & Goldwyn (1984) Adult Attachment Interview · Siegel (2012) The Developing Mind · Porges (2011)

The human in you is the human in me

THE HEARTHSTONE

Anchor	*Neff — common humanity; Buber — I and Thou*

Description	Common humanity counters shame's isolation. Buber's I-Thou: genuine encounter in which neither person is reduced to an object. No hierarchy of suffering. No cult of the enlightened. The constant journey toward one another. This recognition is both neuroscience and theology.
References	Neff (2003) Self and Identity · Buber (1923/1970) I and Thou · Siegel (2007) The Mindful Brain · Rodriguez & Ouellette (2000)

The Mystical Thread

5 stars

The via negativa

THE MYSTICAL THREAD

Anchor	*Pseudo-Dionysius; Cloud of Unknowing; Meister Eckhart; Keller (2015)*
Description	Knowing the sacred through what cannot be said. Structurally queer in its logic — resisting every institutional closure. Eckhart's Gelassenheit: letting-go, releasement. Keller's Cloud of the Impossible brings apophatic theology into conversation with quantum physics and queer theory. The mystery is not a problem to solve but the water you are already swimming in.
References	Cloud of Unknowing (c.1375) · Eckhart — Complete Mystical Works (trans. Walshe) · Keller (2015) Cloud of the Impossible · Boesel & Keller (2010) Apophatic Bodies

Kenosis — self-emptying

THE MYSTICAL THREAD

Anchor	*Coakley; Cheng — radical love; Teilhard*
Description	The divine act of relinquishing power — reread by feminist and queer theologians as freely chosen vulnerability that is itself strength. Cheng's radical love: the dissolution of boundaries mirrors contemplative non-dual awareness. Emptying not from depletion but from abundance.
References	Coakley (2002) Powers and Submissions · Cheng (2011) Radical Love · Teilhard (1960) The Divine Milieu · Keller (2003) Face of the Deep

Non-dual awareness

THE MYSTICAL THREAD

Anchor	*Advaita Vedanta — Ramana Maharshi; Zen — Suzuki; Josipovic (2014)*
Description	Awareness prior to the subject-object split — documented across Vedanta, Zen, Sufism, and Christian mysticism. Josipovic found distinctive neural signatures. Cheng: queer theology's dissolution of fixed identity mirrors this contemplative ground. Not a state to achieve but what is always already present beneath the grasping.
References	Suzuki (1970) Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind · Josipovic (2014) Annals of the New York

	Academy of Sciences · Michaelson (2011) Everything Is God · Cheng (2011) Radical Love

Discernment

THE MYSTICAL THREAD

Anchor	*Teresa of Ávila; IFS Self-energy — Schwartz; Mark & Jankowski (2021)*
Description	The skill to sense what is life-giving versus death-dealing — what deserves our precious lifeforce. Teresa's Interior Castle: the seven mansions as a map of contemplative deepening. IFS Self-energy: curiosity, calm, compassion, courage as the navigator's compass. For LGBTQ+ practitioners, discernment has often been forged in survival.
References	Teresa of Ávila — Interior Castle · Schwartz (1995) IFS · Mark & Jankowski (2021) Pastoral Psychology · Fortunato (1982) Embracing the Exile

Cross-traditional encounter

THE MYSTICAL THREAD

Anchor	*Merton; Thich Nhat Hanh; Rumi; Michaelson*
Description	Something recognizable passes between traditions across enormous differences of form. Rumi's Masnavi is saturated with same-sex desire — often suppressed in Western translation. Michaelson holds LGBTQ+ identity and Jewish mystical practice together without dissolving either.
References	Merton (1968) Zen and the Birds of Appetite · Thich Nhat Hanh (1988) The Heart of Understanding · Rumi — Masnavi · Michaelson (2011) Everything Is God · Leyland (1998) Queer Dharma

The Engaged Path

4 stars

Liberation theology

THE ENGAGED PATH

Anchor	*Gutiérrez; Cone; Althaus-Reid — Indecent Theology*
Description	The sacred located in the bodies of the marginalized. Althaus-Reid: honest theology must begin from the body as it actually is — not as institution demands. Cone: God is found among those who suffer. Indecent theology refuses to sanitise the body, desire, or politics.
References	Gutiérrez (1971) A Theology of Liberation · Cone (1970) A Black Theology of Liberation · Althaus-Reid (2000) Indecent Theology · Althaus-Reid (2003) The Queer God

Engaged practice

THE ENGAGED PATH

Anchor	*Thich Nhat Hanh; Merton; hooks; Lorde*
Description	Inner transformation and outer transformation are not separate projects. Contemplation that does not turn outward toward justice risks — as Merton wrote — becoming a sophisticated form of spiritual self-indulgence. Lorde: the erotic as a source of knowledge and resistance.
References	Thich Nhat Hanh (1987) Being Peace · hooks (1994) Teaching to Transgress · Lorde (1984) Sister Outsider · Rothberg (2006) The Engaged Spiritual Life

Lo cotidiano — the sacred daily

THE ENGAGED PATH

Anchor	*Mujerista theology — Isasi-Díaz; Womanist theology — Williams*
Description	The everyday, the communal, and the embodied as sites of the sacred. Isasi-Díaz's lo cotidiano: daily life as the locus of theological reflection. No specialness required. The ordinary is already holy. The kitchen table is a theological location.
References	Isasi-Díaz (1993) En la Lucha · Williams (1993) Sisters in the Wilderness · Townes (1993) A Troubling in My Soul

Permission surrendered

THE ENGAGED PATH

Anchor	*Apophatic theology; IFS — Schwartz; Brown — shame research*
Description	Deciding goodness is not granted by any institution or system. Releasing the manager-parts that sought approval from power. Naming the system rather than internalizing it is the first act of liberation. You were always enough.
References	Brown (2010) The Gifts of Imperfection · Schwartz (1995) Internal Family Systems · Fortunato (1982) Embracing the Exile · White (1994) Stranger at the Gate

The Wide Waters

4 stars

Earth as theological partner

THE WIDE WATERS

Anchor	*Berry — The Dream of the Earth; Margulis — symbiogenesis; Sheldrake; queer ecology*
Description	Eukaryotic life arose through symbiosis, not competition. Forests are networks of mutual dependency. The universe is a communion of subjects. The same logic that hoards power over queer bodies also justifies the domination of Earth. Queer ecology names these refusals as one refusal.
References	Berry (1988) The Dream of the Earth · Sheldrake (2020) Entangled Life · Sandilands & Erickson (2010) Queer Ecologies · Abram (1996) The Spell of the Sensuous

Interbeing

THE WIDE WATERS

Anchor	*Thich Nhat Hanh; Naess — deep ecology; Abram — phenomenology*
Description	The radical interdependence of all phenomena. There is no separate self that could be saved or damned alone. Naess's deep ecology: the expansion of identity to include the living world. Abram's phenomenology: returning perception to the animate earth. The ecological and the contemplative are one movement.
References	Thich Nhat Hanh (1988) Interbeing · Naess (1989) Ecology, Community and Lifestyle · Abram (1996) The Spell of the Sensuous · Gaard (1993) Ecofeminism

The mystery held openly

THE WIDE WATERS

Anchor	*Cloud of Unknowing; Keats — negative capability; Anil Seth*
Description	No cult. No surprise. The constant journey. Keats: remaining in uncertainty without irritable reaching after fact. Seth: the self is not a fixed thing but a process, forever becoming. Open hands. The apophatic and the scientific arrive at the same posture.
References	Cloud of Unknowing (c.1375) · James (1902) Varieties of Religious Experience · Otto (1917) The Idea of the Holy · Seth (2021) Being You

Purpose as love expressed

THE WIDE WATERS

Anchor	*Tedeschi & Calhoun — post-traumatic growth; Frankl — logotherapy; Nouwen*
Description	Post-traumatic growth research documents deeper relational capacity and clearer purpose following the metabolization of suffering. Frankl: meaning is found not despite suffering but through the stance one takes toward it. The wounded healer — love finding form.
References	Tedeschi & Calhoun (1996) PTG Research · Frankl (1946) Man's Search for Meaning · Nouwen (1972) The Wounded Healer

The Dark Night

4 stars

Grief as sacred work

THE DARK NIGHT

Anchor	*John of the Cross — Dark Night; Levine — grief completion; womanist theology*
Description	John of the Cross: the dark night is not punishment but a necessary passage — the soul

	being freed from attachments that cannot hold the weight of love. Grief is the body completing the response to loss. Womanist theology names grief as politically necessary — the refusal to pretend systemic wounds did not happen.
References	John of the Cross — Dark Night of the Soul · Levine (1987) Healing into Life and Death · Williams (1993) Sisters in the Wilderness · Halifax (2008) Being with Dying

The dark night of the soul

THE DARK NIGHT

Anchor	*John of the Cross; Underhill — Mysticism; Grof — spiritual emergency*
Description	Underhill's Mysticism charts the purgative, illuminative, and unitive ways — descent precedes ascent. Grof's spiritual emergency: profound transformative experiences can look like breakdown. The dark night is not pathology. It is the dissolution of what cannot survive the encounter with love.
References	Underhill (1911) Mysticism · John of the Cross — Ascent of Mount Carmel · Grof & Grof (1989) Spiritual Emergency · Nouwen (1975) Reaching Out

Conscious dying and accompaniment

THE DARK NIGHT

Anchor	*Halifax — GRACE model; Levine; Tibetan Buddhism*
Description	Halifax's GRACE model: Gather attention, Recall intention, Attune to self and other, Consider what will serve, Engage and end. Death as the great teacher of impermanence. Grief and mortality as the deepest teachers of non-extraction.
References	Halifax (2008) Being with Dying · Levine (1982) Who Dies? · Sogyal Rinpoche (1992) The Tibetan Book of Living and Dying

Non-extractive love

THE DARK NIGHT

Anchor	*Process theology — kenotic love; Neff — self-compassion sustains giving; Murdoch*
Description	Love that doesn't demand return, doesn't consolidate power, doesn't require the beloved to be other than they are. Neff's research shows self-compassion — not self-esteem — predicts the capacity to give care without burnout. You cannot sustain non-extractive love while at war with yourself. The dark night teaches this.
References	Neff (2011) Self-Compassion · Murdoch (1970) The Sovereignty of Good · Whitehead — Process and Reality · Cobb & Griffin (1976) Process Theology

The Queer Path

6 stars

Second-satan-induced trauma

THE QUEER PATH

Anchor	*Althaus-Reid; Winell — religious trauma; van der Kolk; Foucault*
Description	The second satan — any system that hoards power and enforces it through the policing of bodies — leaves the body carrying its violence: religious systems, medical systems, carceral systems, colonial logic, family systems that replicated institutional cruelty, workplaces that extract and discard. The body holds all of these in the same way. Naming the system, not internalizing the wound, is where the path begins.
References	Winell (1993) Leaving the Fold · Ryan et al. (2009) — family rejection outcomes · Shidlo et al. (2001) — conversion therapy harms · Foucault (1978) History of Sexuality · van der Kolk (2014) · Althaus-Reid (2000) Indecent Theology

Exile as contemplative location

THE QUEER PATH

Anchor	*Fortunato (1982) — Embracing the Exile; Tigert (1996); Alison (2003)*
Description	Exile from any second-satan system is not a spiritual dead end but a contemplative location. The wilderness as the place where the divine is most honestly encountered. The margin becomes the centre. The exile knows things the insider cannot.
References	Fortunato (1982) Embracing the Exile · Tigert (1996) Coming Out Through Fire · Alison (2003) On Being Liked · McNeil (1988) Taking a Chance on God

The body as theological site

THE QUEER PATH

Anchor	*Althaus-Reid; Isherwood & Stuart (1998); Kugle — Sufi bodies*
Description	The particular, marked, desiring, gendered, racialised body is not an obstacle to contemplative life but its very site and medium. This is queer theology's most consistent and radical gift to the broader contemplative tradition. Kugle's work on Sufi saints' bodies: holiness was never disembodied.
References	Isherwood & Stuart (1998) Introducing Body Theology · Althaus-Reid (2000) Indecent Theology · Kugle (2007) Sufis and Saints' Bodies · Butler (1993) Bodies That Matter

Two-spirit and gender-plural traditions

THE QUEER PATH

Anchor	*Roscoe (1998); Conner (1993); Nanda (1990)*
Description	Non-Western contemplative traditions have held gender plurality as sacred for millennia. Two-spirit roles in Native North American traditions, hijra traditions in South Asia, gender-plural sacred roles across Southeast Asia — these are ancient contemplative wisdom suppressed by colonial second-satan logic.
References	Roscoe (1998) Changing Ones · Conner (1993) Blossom of Bone · Nanda (1990) Neither

	Man nor Woman · Peletz (2009) Gender Pluralism · Deloria (1999) Spirit and Reason

Queer mysticism

THE QUEER PATH

Anchor	*Moore (1985); Keller (2003); Loughlin (2007); Jordan (2014)*
Description	The contemplative tradition's use of erotic language — Rumi, John of the Cross, the Song of Songs — has always exceeded heteronormative containment. Jordan's Foucault work: contemplative practice has been used both to discipline and to liberate desire. The mystics were often queerer than their institutions.
References	Moore (1985) The Fire and the Rose Are One · Keller (2003) Face of the Deep · Loughlin (2007) Queer Theology · Jordan (2014) Convulsing Bodies · Cheng (2011) Radical Love

Identity integration

THE QUEER PATH

Anchor	*Rodriguez & Ouellette (2000); Lease et al. (2005); Riggle et al. (2008)*
Description	Affirming communities significantly predict psychological wellbeing for LGBTQ+ people. Riggle et al. document genuine post-traumatic growth and positive identity dimensions of LGBTQ+ experience. Integration is not the erasure of the wound but the discovery that the wound has been generative.
References	Rodriguez & Ouellette (2000) Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion · Lease et al. (2005) Journal of Counseling Psychology · Riggle et al. (2008) · Dahl & Galliher (2012) · Pargament (2007)

The Making

6 stars

Making as praying

THE MAKING

Anchor	*McNiff — Art as Medicine; Allen — open studio; Loori — Zen of Creativity*
Description	What distinguishes contemplative art practice from art-making in general is not the medium or the product but the quality of attention brought to the process. The contemplative artist is not primarily making an object but cultivating a state of presence. McNiff: the image has its own healing intelligence. Loori: creativity is itself a gate of Zen practice.
References	McNiff (1992) Art as Medicine · Allen (1995) Art Is a Way of Knowing · Loori (2004) The Zen of Creativity · Cameron (1992) The Artist's Way · Nachmanovitch (1990) Free Play

The pre-verbal path

THE MAKING

Anchor	*Levine S.K. — poiesis; Pennebaker — expressive writing; Kaimal et al.*
Description	Art-making reaches forms of experience that language cannot access — not because language is insufficient but because some experience is stored in image, movement, and sensation rather than word. Kaimal et al.: art-making reduces cortisol regardless of prior artistic experience.
References	Levine S.K. (1992) Poiesis · Pennebaker & Beall (1986) Journal of Abnormal Psychology · Kaimal et al. (2016) Art Therapy · Malchiodi (2011) Handbook of Art Therapy

Flow as contemplative state

THE MAKING

Anchor	*Csikszentmihalyi (1990); Vessel et al. (2012); Nachmanovitch*
Description	Csikszentmihalyi's flow — absorbed, effortless engagement — characterises both contemplative and creative experience at their deepest. Vessel et al. found that profound aesthetic experience activates the same default mode network as self-referential thought and meditation. Making and meditating may be neurologically closer than we thought.
References	Csikszentmihalyi (1990) Flow · Vessel et al. (2012) Frontiers in Human Neuroscience · Nachmanovitch (1990) Free Play · Winnicott (1971) Playing and Reality

Making together as sacred assembly

THE MAKING

Anchor	*Dissanayake (1988); Taizé; Rogers N. (1993)*
Description	Many of the most significant contemplative art practices — sacred chant, communal weaving, liturgical dance, the Taizé model — are inherently communal rather than solitary. Making together is itself a form of being together in the presence of something larger than any individual creative will.
References	Dissanayake (1988) What Is Art For? · Rogers N. (1993) The Creative Connection · Knill et al. (2005) Principles and Practice of Expressive Arts Therapy · Goldberg (1986) Writing Down the Bones

Process over product

THE MAKING

Anchor	*McNiff (1998); Cameron (1992); Lamott (1994)*
Description	The liberation from skill anxiety that contemplative art practice offers resonates deeply for those whose bodies and identities have been judged and found wanting by second-satan systems. The shitty first draft is a contemplative practice. Trust the process. The image knows something you do not yet know.
References	McNiff (1998) Trust the Process · Cameron (1992) The Artist's Way · Lamott (1994) Bird by Bird · Allen (2005) Art Is a Spiritual Path

Authentic movement and somatic art

THE MAKING

Anchor	*Adler (2002); Whitehouse (1979); Eddy (2016)*
Description	Authentic Movement: movement as active imagination, the body as the site of inner knowing. Not performance but presence. The body remembers what the mind has not yet found language for. Somatic art practice brings the contemplative fully into the cellular.
References	Adler (2002) Offering from the Conscious Body · Whitehouse (1979) — foundational AM paper · Eddy (2016) Mindful Movement · Chodorow (1991) Dance Therapy and Depth Psychology

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No cult. No surprise. Just the constant journey toward.

Andrea Robin Studio · path-to-good · github.com/andrearobinstudio/path-to-good